

REFUELING UDAN

THE FIRST PHASE OF UDAN GOT A MIXED RESPONSE AFTER THE END OF THE SUBSIDY PERIOD. WILL THE MODIFIED SCHEME HELP INDIAN AVIATION PERFORM TO ITS FULL POTENTIAL?

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► **THE GOVERNMENT LAUNCHED** its flagship regional connectivity scheme (RCS)—Ude Desh Ka Aam Nagrik (UDAN)—in 2016. The ambition? What the name says. Making flights accessible and affordable for the common man.

The first phase of the scheme, ending this year, ensured regional connectivity to unserved destinations. In the last 10 years, 92 unserved and underserved airports were operationalised under the scheme, of which 14 are now non-

operational, with the government footing the ₹900 crore bill on their maintenance. Half the routes have been discontinued and only a quarter remain self-sustainable at the end of the three-year subsidy period.

UDAN airports now account for 58% share of airports in India. However, these typically have limited flight operations. Despite expansion, UDAN airports contributed a relatively small share to domestic passenger traffic in

₹3,661
CRORE

To build 200
helipads in
10 years

₹2,577
CRORE

Operations and
maintenance support to
441 aerodromes

120
CONNECTIONS

to new destinations, catering
40 million passengers,
over the next 10 years